

SOC Severity, Disposition & Escalation Matrix

Decision support for Tier 1 triage and handoff

Level	When to use	Examples	Tier 1 action
Critical	Active widespread compromise, major outage, ransomware, confirmed sensitive-data exposure, critical privileged compromise.	Ransomware across many hosts; confirmed admin takeover with destructive activity.	Immediate incident escalation; preserve evidence; authorized containment; continuous status.
High	Confirmed malicious activity or strong compromise evidence with important but bounded scope.	Brute force followed by success; suspicious PowerShell with persistence; successful phishing credential theft.	Rapid containment per runbook; complete evidence summary; Tier 2/IR handoff.
Medium	Suspicious activity needs investigation; impact limited or confidence incomplete.	Failure-only brute force; single suspicious connection; endpoint behavior without corroboration.	Investigate, scope, enrich, and escalate if confidence/impact increases.
Low	Informational or low-risk event, often blocked or routine.	Blocked scan, known benign activity, low-confidence enrichment alert.	Document and close or route to tuning/standard queue.

Escalate Regardless of Initial Alert Severity

- Privileged/admin account involvement.
- Successful unauthorized authentication.
- Persistence, lateral movement, credential dumping/access, or remote execution.
- Sensitive/regulated data access or exfiltration concern.
- Multiple users/hosts or rapidly expanding scope.
- Business-critical service impact.
- Evidence destruction or anti-forensics.
- Threat remains active after Tier 1 containment.